The Medical Profession – A Collection

By Anne Sexton, David Schiedermayer and John Stone

From "Doctors"

They work with herbs
and penicillin
They work with gentleness
and the scalpel.
They dig out the cancer,
close an incision
and say a prayer
to the poverty of the skin.
They are not Gods
though they would like to be;
they are only a human
trying to fix up a human.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Anne Sexton
Book: Poetry in Medicine: An Anthology of Poems About Doctors, Patients, Illness and Healing
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INTRODUCTION

When you were a child, what did you want to be when you grew up? An astronaut. A professional athlete . . . a doctor? Many children change their answer as they grow older. But for some, medicine will always be their calling. There's a sense of pride in helping others – providing care in the direst of times. The poem, Gaudeamus Igitur by John Stone was presented to the graduates of Emory University School of Medicine in 1982.

From "Gaudeamus Igitur" *

* *Therefore, let us rejoice*

For this is the day of joy
    For this is the day you know too little
    against the day when you will know too much
For you will be invincible
    and vulnerable in the same breath
    which is the breath of your patients
For their breath is our breathing and our reason
For the patient will know the answer
    and you will ask him
    ask her
For the family may know the answer
For there may be no answer

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and you will know too little again
or there will be an answer and you will know too much
forever
For you will look smart and feel ignorant
and the patient will not know which day it is for you
and you will pretend to be smart out of ignorance
For you must fear ignorance more than cyanosis
For you will cry and there will be no one to talk to
or no one but yourself
For you will be lonely
For you will be alone
For there is a difference
For the days will run together in gallops and the years
go by as fast as the speed of thought
which is faster than the speed of light
or Superman
or Superwoman
For you will not be Superman
For you will not be Superwoman

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For this is the end of examinations
For this is the beginning of testing
For Death will give the final examination
and everyone will pass
For the best hospital is a house of joy
even with rooms of pain and loss
exits of misunderstanding
For there is the mortar of faith
For it helps to believe
For disease will peer up over the hedge
of health, with only its eyes showing
For you can be trained to listen only for the oboe
out of the whole orchestra
For you may need to strain to hear the voice of the patient
in the thin reed of his crying
For you will learn to see most acutely out of
the corner of your eye
to hear best with your inner ear
For there are late signs and early signs
For the patient's story will come to you

like hunger, like thirst
For you will know the answer
like second nature, like first
For the patient will live
and you will try to understand
For you will be amazed
or the patient will not live
and you will try to understand
For you will be baffled
For you will try to explain both, either, to the family
For love is what death would always intend if it had the choice
For there will be days of joy
For there will be elevators of elation
and you will walk triumphantly
in purest joy
along the halls of the hospital
and say Yes to all the dark corners
where no one is listening
For the heart will lead
For the head will explain

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but the final common pathway is the heart
whatever kingdom may come
For what matters finally is how the human spirit is spent
For this is the day of joy
For this is the morning to rejoice
For this is the beginning
Therefore, let us rejoice
Gaudeamus igitur.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: John Stone
Book: Music from Apartment 8: New and Selected Poems
ISBN: 978-0807129548
Publisher: LSU Press
Date (Month/Year): 2004

TRANSITION

But let's bring the practice of medicine to a more personal level. One doctor, one patient – a fight for a life. Fighting Bare-Handed by David Schiedermayer

Fighting Bare-Handed

Last night, Saturday night
I fought death bare-handed
in and over the body
of a 61 year-old man
with liver and kidney failure
which started and worsened
after his back surgery.
I had a bad feeling at about 6 pm,
looking at his 4 pm labs,
so I went to his room and found him
barely breathing. Breathing once
or maybe twice a minute.
So I sat by his bed
and I begged him to breathe
I pinched his toes when he stopped.

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Once, when he had stopped for a minute,
and I am not proud of this,
but it is just true,
I rubbed my bare knuckles right across
the staples on his abdomen
(they had operated his back from both
the back and the front to fix the bones)
and he woke up with a start
and a grimace
and said, "what do you want me to do?"
And knowing how death was possessing him,
I said "Breathe!" to him, not to death,
and he took a big breath before he
fell back to sleep.
And so I kept him alive until we could
move him down to the ICU, waited with him
for an hour in that quiet room at the very end
of the orthopedics unit, just me and him and death,
me pinching him every minute
death quietly creeping in and through
I pinched him and shook him

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and used Narcan to fight the morphine

so he would have a chance to breathe

And when I went home

I laughed a little as I walked across the driveway

I skipped up the steps

because

in the ICU they were giving him all kinds of medicine

and putting in all kinds of lines

but me

I guess I really do

like a good bare-knuckled fight on a Saturday night.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: David Schiedermayer
Book: House Calls, Rounds, and Healings: A Poetry Casebook
ISBN: 978-1883620172
Publisher: Galen Press Ltd
Date (Month/Year): October 1, 1996

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